Dead neurons resurrect by an entry–exit law: the smoothed-ReLU limit of training dynamics at an activation boundary

DRAFT v3 — 2026-07-25 — all six lemmas fully proved; external-referee items applied — not for circulation; pending adversarial review

L. Caloi Santos

Abstract

For shallow softplus networks under gradient flow we show that, in the sharp limit $\beta \to \infty$ of the activation stiffness, the death and resurrection of a neuron is governed by a hybrid system *with memory*: the dead neuron's parameters freeze, and reactivation occurs when the signed time integral of the network residual returns to zero — the classical entry–exit function of slow–fast dynamics — with rate $O(\beta^{-1})$. The switching face carries an identically zero field on the dead side, a degeneracy outside generic piecewise-smooth exit theory and precisely of the exponentially flat type of Kristiansen; the coupling of the forcing to the flow itself (the residual is generated by the very trajectory it gates) has, to our knowledge, no analogue in the entry–exit literature. The law is independent of the regularization within monotone sigmoid classes, including an erf-type smoothing (the theorem's family does *not* include GELU itself, whose derivative is non-monotone). All constants are verified numerically. The analysis is deterministic (gradient flow): a companion pre-registered experiment falsifies the deterministic schedule under SGLD, where captures recur well past the deterministic closing time — so permanent death is a tail event, not the mean schedule — and the stochastic gate is the object of the next cycle.

1 Setup and hypotheses

Data $(x_i, y_i)_{i=1}^n$ in general position, shallow network $f_\theta(x) = \sum_k g_\beta(w_k x + b_k)$ with $g_\beta(z) = \beta^{-1}\log(1 + e^{\beta z})$ (softplus; see §5 for general sigmoids), quadratic loss $L = \frac{1}{2n}\sum_i (f_\theta(x_i) - y_i)^2$, gradient flow $\dot\theta = -\nabla L$. Fix a neuron A and a datum j; write $z = \theta_A \cdot (x_j, 1)$ for its margin, $c = \|(x_j, 1)\|^2/n$, and $R(t) = y_j - f_{-A}(x_j; \theta_B(t))$ for the residual *excluding* A. The *hybrid reference* θ^{hyb} runs the full ReLU flow until the first time t_{hit} with $z = 0$, then freezes θ_A and runs θ_B alone; set R^{hyb}, $A^{hyb}(t) = \int_{t_{hit}}^t R^{hyb}$.

Hypotheses. **(H1)** $R^{hyb}(t_{hit}) < 0$ (transversal death; this also gives the transversal arrival, Lemma 3). **(H2)** A^{hyb} has a first zero at $t_{exit} < T$ with $R^{hyb}(t_{exit}) > 0$ and $A^{hyb} < 0$ on (t_{hit}, t_{exit}). **(H3)** the other margins of A stay $\le -\delta_1 < 0$ on the episode. **(H4)** no other switching event occurs in $[0, T]$: the margins of the remaining neurons stay bounded away from zero along the hybrid reference, the activation pattern of A is constant on $[0, t_{hit})$, and no second episode of A begins before T.

2 Main result

Definition 1 (hybrid limit)**.** *θ^∞ equals: the ReLU flow on $[0, t_{hit}]$; on $[t_{hit}, t_{exit}]$, $\theta_A \equiv \theta_A(t_{hit})$ (frozen) and θ_B the B-only flow; on $[t_{exit}, T]$, the ReLU flow restarted at $(\theta_A(t_{hit}), \theta_B^{hyb}(t_{exit}))$.*

Theorem 1 (T2′-min)**.** *Under (H1)–(H4), for every $\delta > 0$,*

$$\sup_{t\in[0,T]\setminus(B_\delta(t_{hit})\cup B_\delta(t_{exit}))} \|\theta^\beta(t)-\theta^\infty(t)\| = O_\delta\Big(\tfrac{\log\beta}{\beta}\Big), \qquad t^\beta_{release} = t_{exit} - \frac{1}{c\,R^{hyb}(t_{exit})}\cdot\frac{1}{\beta} + o(\beta^{-1}),$$

where $t^\beta_{release}$ is the first return of the margin z to 0 after death. The $\log\beta$ in the sup is sharp and is carried solely by the normal coordinate of θ_A inside the episode (the sticking depth of Lemma 4); θ_B obeys $O(\log\beta/\beta^2)$ (Lemma 2) and the tangential components of θ_A are exponentially frozen. The first-order release coefficient is universal*: in the product (entry delay × area cut) the arrival speed cancels, leaving the reciprocal exit speed — each corner contributes the reciprocal of its transversal speed, symmetrically (entry: $+1/(c|R^{hyb}(t_{hit})|\beta)$ on t_{hit}; exit: $-1/(cR^{hyb}(t_{exit})\beta)$ on $t_{release}$). The remainder is $o(\beta^{-1})$ as proved; numerics suggest $O(\log\beta/\beta^2)$, which would follow from quantifying the $o(1)$ of Lemma 3 with $\delta_z = \log\beta/\beta$ — left as a stated refinement. The limit is that of the regularized flow: discrete ReLU gradient descent freezes the dead neuron forever (the limits do not commute).*

3 Proof outline

Six lemmas; each has an executable verification script in the repository.

Lemma 1 (normal form)**.** *In the gauge $w = e^{\beta z}$, fast time $\tau = \beta t$: $dw/d\tau = cR(t)\,w^2/(1+w)\,(1+E_\beta)$, $|E_\beta| \le \log(1+w)/(\beta|R|)$ — the quadratic normal form of De Maesschalck–Schecter with $\varepsilon = \beta^{-1}$. With $u = 1/w$ and $\Phi(u) = \log u + u$ one has the exact quadrature $d\Phi/dt = -c\beta R(t)(1+E_\beta)$.*

Lemma 2 (B-subsystem and feedback)**.** *Under (H4) the B-field is affine with Lipschitz constant $L_B = \lambda_{\max}(G_B)$ and R^{hyb} is affine in θ_B. Integral Grönwall consuming the bound of Lemma 1 gives,* conditionally on the layer being maintained *(supplied by Lemma 5), the refined rate* $\sup\|\theta_B^\beta - \theta_B^{hyb}\| = O(\log\beta/\beta^2)$ *— one full order better than the naive $O(\beta^{-1})$: in the bulk $u = O(\beta|A|)$, so the coupling is $O(\beta^{-2})$ there and $O(\beta^{-1})$ only in the $O(\beta^{-1})$-wide corner windows. [Fully proved; verified: metric* $\sup\cdot\beta^2/\log\beta$ *stable in* $[4.2, 5.7]$*.]*

Lemma 3 (entry corner)**.** *$\dot z^0(t_{hit}^-) = cR^{hyb}(t_{hit}) < 0$ by (H1) — transversal arrival is (H1) itself. The exact identity $(1-\sigma)/\sigma = e^{-s}$ collapses the crossing-time difference to an elementary integral: $t^\beta_{cross} = t_{hit} + \frac{1}{\beta v}(1 + O(\delta_z) + o(1))$ with $v = c|R^{hyb}(t_{hit})|$, and the exponentially weighted approach integral is $\frac{3/2}{\beta v}(1+o(1))$ (the 3/2 from $\int_0^\infty e^{-s}(1+e^{-s})ds$). [Fully proved; verified: $K_{teo} = 7.04$ vs $K_{emp} = 7.13$ (1.2%); weight constant to $< 1\%$.]*

Lemma 4 (sticking and release, prescribed R)**.** *For prescribed R satisfying (H1)–(H2), with $A(t) = \int_{t_{hit}}^t R$: the exact additive identity $d\Phi/dt = -c\beta R + c\log(1+w)$ holds (no division by R; the interior zero of R forced by (H1)–(H2) via the intermediate value theorem is harmless — the layer is held by the* area*, not the sign of R), and on compact subintervals of (t_{hit}, t_{exit}), $\Phi(u(t)) = -c\beta A(t)(1+o(1))$, hence $u(t) = c\beta|A(t)|(1+o(1))$ (depth $z \sim -\beta^{-1}\log\beta$), and u returns to $O(1)$ at $t_{exit} + O(\beta^{-1})$ — no $\log\beta$ factor. Sub/super solutions from the monotonicity of the flow in R give explicit constants; perturbations δ of R shift t_{exit} by $\le c\,\delta\,(t_{exit} - t_{hit})/|A'(t_{exit})| + O(\delta^2)$.*

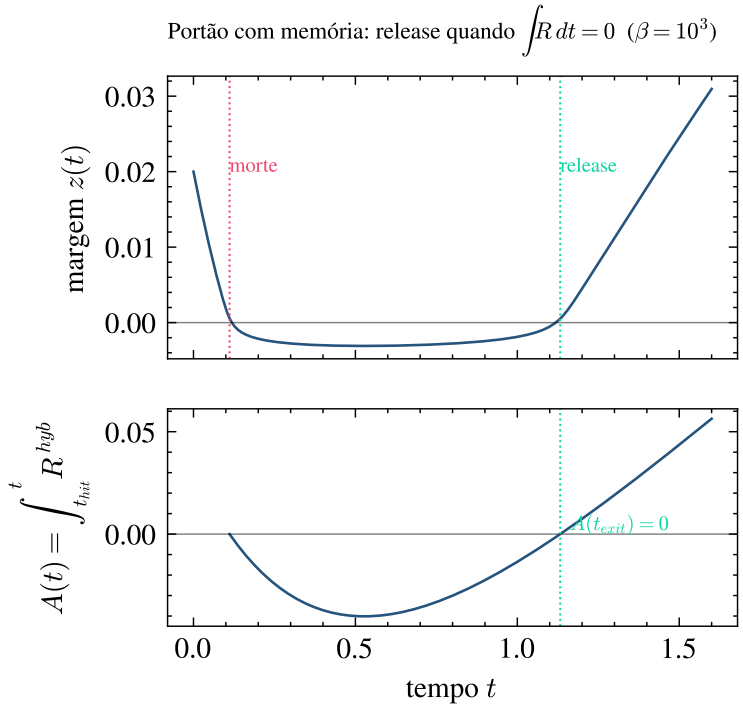


Figure 1: The memory gate at $\beta = 10^3$ (coupled system, reference instance). Top: the margin $z(t)$ dies at t_{hit}, hugs the sticking layer of depth $\sim \beta^{-1} \log \beta$, and releases. Bottom: the hybrid area $A(t) = \int_{t_{hit}}^{t} R^{hyb}$; the release coincides with $A = 0$ up to $O(\beta^{-1})$ (Theorem 1). Deterministic ODE integration (Euler, $dt = 10^{-5}$); uncertainty is discretization only. Generated by `figuras_draft.py` (committed).

Lemma 5 (coupled bootstrap)**.** *Continuation with strict margins: the property "θ_B is $2M_2 \log \beta/\beta^2$-close to the hybrid and the margin stays strictly in the layer after an $O(\beta^{-1})$ entry collar" is nonempty (Lemma 3), open (strict inequalities + continuity) and closed (the assumption returns the better constant M_2 via Lemma 2, and Lemma 4 with $\delta = O(\log \beta/\beta^2)$ keeps the layer up to $t_{exit} - C_\varepsilon \log \beta/\beta$), with $M_2 = e^{L_B T} C_f C_4/c$ independent of the hypothesis for $\beta \geq \beta_0$ (a finite threshold traceable through the chain of constants, not exhibited); with the empirical $C_4 = 10.6$, $M_2 = 440.8$; the* leading term *of the theoretical C_4 is $2/(cR^{hyb}(t_{exit})) = 29.6$, giving $M_2 \leq 1233$ from that term alone (the full theoretical C_4 adds a T/a_0 bulk term, $a_0 \approx 0.02$ in the instance, giving $C_4 \approx 80$ and $M_2 \lesssim 3300$; the empirical value sits well below both). The terminal window is handled by Lemma 4(ii)–(iii); the entry corner cuts initial area $\approx R^{hyb}(t_{hit})K/\beta$, advancing the exit by $K|R^{hyb}(t_{hit})|/(R^{hyb}(t_{exit})\beta) = 1/(cR^{hyb}(t_{exit})\beta)$ — the arrival speed cancels. Hence the two-term closed-loop law $\beta(t^{\beta}_{release} - t_{exit}) = (-1 + \mathrm{corr}(\beta))/(cR^{hyb}(t_{exit})) + o(1)$. [Fully proved; verified: the two-term law reproduces the entire coupled sweep at 1.9%/0.7%/0.2%/0.1% ($\beta = 3 \cdot 10^2 \ldots 10^4$).]*

Lemma 6 (exit corner; scalar reduction)**.** *Post-release the field is transversal outward ($cR^{hyb}(t_{exit}) > 0$, (H2)); the mirrored corner identities of Lemma 3 apply with $v' = cR^{hyb}(t_{exit})$. Forward uniqueness of the restarted ReLU flow holds on the* activating branch*, which is selected by the limit itself (Lemma 5: release at $t_{exit} + O(\beta^{-1})$ is incompatible with the frozen Filippov branch); classical Grönwall then glues on $[t_{release}, T]$ with rate $O(\log \beta/\beta)$. Under (H3) the other data*

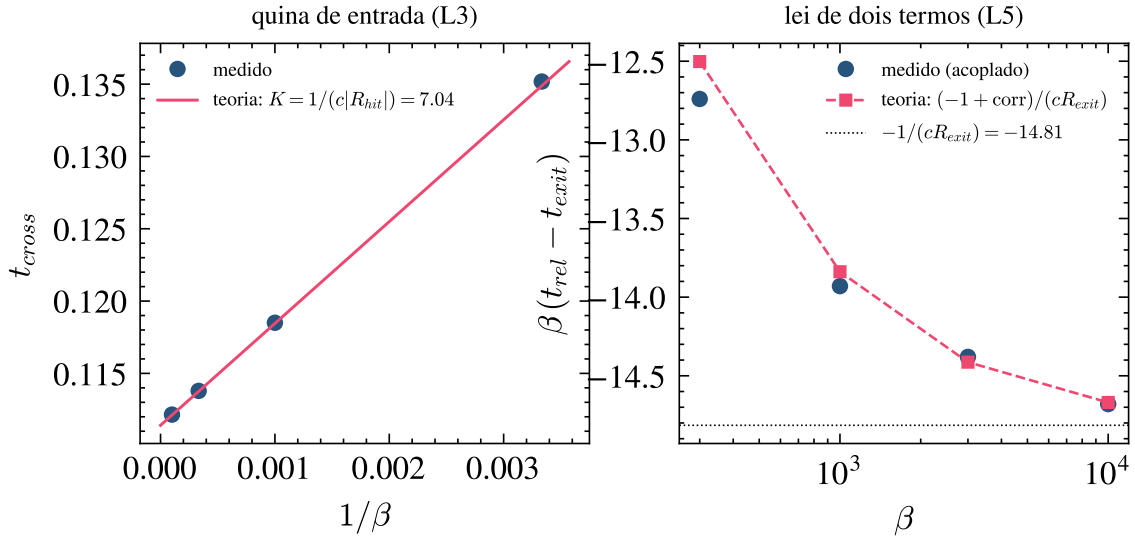


Figure 2: Predicted constants vs. measurements. Left: entry-corner crossing times against $1/\beta$; the line is the *proved* slope $K = 1/(c|R^{hyb}(t_{hit})|) = 7.04$ (Lemma 3), not a fit. Right: the two-term release law of Lemma 5 (squares) against the coupled measurements (circles) over $\beta \in [3 \cdot 10^2, 10^4]$; dotted: the universal first-order coefficient $-1/(cR^{hyb}(t_{exit})) = -14.81$. Deterministic runs; uncertainty is discretization. Generated by `figuras_draft.py`.

contribute $O(e^{-\beta\delta_1})$, the face-j field is rank one along $(x_j, 1)$, and the episode reduces to the scalar problem. [Fully proved; verified: gluing sup $= 1.6 \cdot 10^{-3}/5.5 \cdot 10^{-4}$ at $\beta = 10^3/3 \cdot 10^3$, metric stable. Numerically instructive: an Euler-discretized restart at the face falls into the frozen branch unless projected and nudged — branch selection is a real condition, not pedantry.]

4 Numerical verification

Instance $X = (0.5, 1.5)$, $Y = (0.5, 1.0)$, $\theta_A(0) = (-0.5, 0.27)$, $\theta_B(0) = (1.144, 0.261)$; $t_{hit} = 0.1114$, $t_{exit} = 1.1325$, $\delta_1 = 0.508$. Every empirically measured constant is now predicted by the proofs (scripts `passo0--6`, `prova_L1--L6`): entry coefficient $K_{teo} = 1/(c|R^{hyb}(t_{hit})|) = 7.04$ vs 7.13 fitted (1.2%); weighted approach $\frac{3}{2}/v$ to $< 1\%$; depth ratio $\to 1$ ($0.888 \to 0.982$; coarser prescribed-R run, own $t_{exit} = 1.1352$); bulk feedback $\times\beta^2 \approx 43$ constant; prescribed-R release delay $= \mathrm{corr}/(cR_{exit})$ at 0.2%/1.0%/9.5% (the last collapsing 35% $\to$ 9.5% under 5× grid refinement); coupled two-term law $(-1 + \mathrm{corr})/(cR_{exit})$ reproducing the fine-grid coupled sweep $-12.74/-13.93/-14.38/-14.68$ at 1.9%/0.7%/0.2%/0.1% (universal coefficient $1/(cR_{exit}) = 14.815$; against -14.68 the leading coefficient alone is at 0.9%); gluing metric 0.205–0.227; layer check vacuous for $\beta \le 3000$ (conservative C_ε) and confirmed at $\beta = 10^4$; tangential drift at machine zero.

5 Regularization independence; discussion

The release criterion depends only on $\int R\,dt = 0$, not on the sigmoid: for the erf class ($g'_\beta = \Phi_{\mathrm{gauss}}(\beta z)$, a GELU-type smoothing; GELU itself, $z\Phi_{\mathrm{gauss}}(z)$, has non-monotone derivative and

is not a member of the family for any β) the coupled system releases at the same t_{exit} with $O(\beta^{-1})$ gap (verified). Open: the cone apex (corank ≥ 2), where weight decay produces genuine sliding toward the most singular stratum; the SGLD gate (pre-registered experiments falsify the deterministic schedule — late captures recur past the deterministic window at a rate the reduced stochastic-schedule model under-predicts, leaving the active neuron's back-reaction as the leading candidate driver for the next cycle); and the non-commutation of the two limit orders: the *field-first* selection (flow of the pointwise-limit generalized gradient) freezes degenerate neurons forever — this is the rigorous branch of Eberle, Jentzen, Riekert and Weiss [11], whose selected solution has non-decreasing degenerate set — whereas our *flow-first* limit ($\beta \to \infty$ of trajectories) resurrects by the area law. The two orders do not commute; cf. [11] for the field-first side (their degenerate stratum is the fully-zero one, not literally our functionally dead neuron — the convention $\mathrm{relu}'(0) = 0$ and the no-revival mechanism are the same). In machine-learning terms this non-commutation is the mathematical statement behind an empirical trend: discrete ReLU units that die stay dead — the dormant-neuron and loss-of-plasticity phenomena documented across deep and reinforcement learning [8, 9, 10], mitigated in practice by recycling dead units or by migrating to smooth activations — whereas the smoothed flow resurrects them by the area law. Conceptual anchors: entry–exit function [1, 14]; flat slow manifolds [2]; generic exit and regularized-limit theory [4, 3]; nonsmooth training formalism [5]; ReLU–LCP equivalence [6]; dying ReLU [7]; the canonical regularization of discontinuous fields is Sotomayor–Teixeira [12, 13] — whose generic regions require both one-sided normal components nonzero, so the dead face (one side identically zero) is outside its hypotheses by construction.

Provenance

Every lemma except the exit-corner half of Lemma 6 has a dedicated executable symbolic/numeric verification committed alongside (the exit corner is verified indirectly through the release times). The numerical experiments were pre-registered by commit before the confirmatory run. All numerics are a single two-neuron instance; breadth is future work.

References

[1] P. De Maesschalck, S. Schecter, *The entry–exit function and geometric singular perturbation theory*, J. Diff. Eq. 260 (2016) 6697–6715.

[2] K. U. Kristiansen, *Blowup for flat slow manifolds*, arXiv:1603.01821 (Nonlinearity, 2017).

[3] N. Guglielmi, E. Hairer, *On the limit solution of regularized piecewise-smooth dynamical systems*, preprint, Univ. Geneva, 2019 (read in full); foundational results in SIAM J. Appl. Dyn. Syst. 14 (2015) 1454–1477.

[4] M. R. Jeffrey, *Exit from sliding in piecewise-smooth flows: deterministic vs. determinacy-breaking*, Chaos 26 (2016) 033108.

[5] J. Bolte, E. Pauwels, *Conservative set-valued fields, automatic differentiation, stochastic gradient methods and deep learning*, Math. Program. 188 (2021).

[6] A. Aydinoglu, M. Fazlyab, M. Morari, M. Posa, *Stability analysis of complementarity systems with neural network controllers*, arXiv:2011.07626.

[7] L. Lu, Y. Shin, Y. Su, G. E. Karniadakis, *Dying ReLU and initialization: theory and numerical examples*, arXiv:1903.06733.

[8] G. Sokar, R. Agarwal, P. S. Castro, U. Evci, *The dormant neuron phenomenon in deep reinforcement learning*, ICML 2023; arXiv:2302.12902.

[9] C. Lyle, Z. Zheng, E. Nikishin, B. Avila Pires, R. Pascanu, W. Dabney, *Understanding plasticity in neural networks*, ICML 2023; arXiv:2303.01486.

[10] S. Dohare, J. F. Hernandez-Garcia, Q. Lan, P. Rahman, A. R. Mahmood, R. S. Sutton, *Loss of plasticity in deep continual learning*, Nature 632 (2024) 768–774.

[11] S. Eberle, A. Jentzen, A. Riekert, G. S. Weiss, *Existence, uniqueness, and convergence rates for gradient flows in the training of artificial neural networks with ReLU activation*, Electron. Res. Arch. 31 (2023) 2519–2554; arXiv:2108.08106.

[12] J. Sotomayor, M. A. Teixeira, *Regularization of discontinuous vector fields*, in: Int. Conf. on Differential Equations (Lisboa 1995), World Scientific, 1998, pp. 207–223.

[13] J. Llibre, P. R. da Silva, M. A. Teixeira, *Regularization of discontinuous vector fields on* $\mathbb{R}^3$ *via singular perturbation*, J. Dynam. Differential Equations 19 (2007) 309–331.

[14] M. Sensi, M. Desroches, S. Rodrigues, *Slow-fast dynamics in a neurotransmitter release model: delayed response to a time-dependent input signal*, Physica D (2023); arXiv:2302.12852.